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Students' DAY SPECIAL



Kalam connect

Only some people have the character and charisma to connect with most others. Our former President, Dr. A. P. J Abdul Kalam, was one of them. Some see him as the 'Missile Man of India'. Certain others view him as the 'People's President'. Others still cherish his association with youngsters, and it is for this reason that his birthday was chosen to be celebrated as World Students' Day in India. Regardless of what it is, almost everyone feels a certain connection with Dr. Kalam. Read on to find out more...

A.S.Ganesh



A LIFETIME OF SCIENCE

In the years leading up to India's independence, a boy was born in the south Indian town of Rameswaram in Tamil Nadu on October 15, 1931. That boy was the youngest of five siblings in a once wealthy family that found itself in difficult times. Despite the circumstances in which he was raised, he stuck with his education. When the country gained independence from British rule, one can imagine the teenager dreaming up a future — for himself, and for his country. He surely set out and achieved all of them, and perhaps more, as Avul Pakir Jainulabdeen Abdul Kalam became one of the most beloved Presidents that the country has ever seen.

With a degree in aeronautical engineering from the Madras Institute of Technology, Dr. Kalam went on to make significant contributions as an Indian scientist. As someone who spent most of his time in the 21st Century meeting and inspiring people, it is easy to forget that Dr. Kalam had spent many decades before that in the 20th Century as a working scientist who put a young independent nation on the world map.

Having joined the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) in 1958, Dr. Kalam switched over to the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) in 1969, before heading back to DRDO in 1982.

From being the project director of the SLV-III (India's first indigenous Satellite Launch Vehicle that was both designed and produced in the country) to planning the Integrated Guided Missile Development Programme (IGMDP) that produced a number of successful missiles, Dr. Kalam had plenty of successes in his career.







(From left to right): Dr. Kalam and fellow space scientist R. Aravamudan assembling the Indian Rocket Payload during the early days of India's space programme; flanked by Dr. Satish Dhawan (second from left), Dr. Kalam (second from right) shows an album of photographs to Prime Minister Indira Gandhi following the successful launching of SLV-III in 1980; serving as the country's President, Dr. Kalam is seen working with a model along with kids in Bengaluru in 2006.

SOARING HIGHER AND HIGHER

The decades that followed saw recognition and accolades come in thick and fast. These included some of India's highest honours: the Padma Bhushan, Padma Vibhushan, and the Bharat Ratna.

The first of those, the Padma Bhushan, came in 1981, with an investiture ceremony in Rashtrapati Bhavan, New Delhi on March 28, allowing Dr. Kalam to receive the award from President N. Sanjeev Reddy (left in right). After picking up the Padma Vibhushan in 1990, Dr. Kalam then served as the Scientific Adviser to Defence Minister and Secretary, Department of Defence Research & Development from July 1992 to December 1999. During this period, Dr. Kalam claimed the Bharat Ratna — the country's highest civilian award. From 1999-2001, he served as the principal scientific adviser to the government.

His time as the scientific adviser to the defence minister coincided with India's growing nuclear capabilities. In collaboration with others, Dr. Kalam led the Pokhran-II nuclear tests, making India a country with nuclear weapons.



"All birds find shelter during a rain. But eagle avoids rain by flying above the clouds. Problems are common, but attitude makes the difference!!!

Dr. Abdul Kalam

A WAY WITH WORDS

He had found strength in words. He had already reached out to many a reader through the written word, with his *Wings of Fire* (1999), his autobiography, and *Ignited Minds* (2002) being notable works. He took to the spoken word as well, addressing youngsters and adults alike in institutional gatherings. People in general, and students in particular, thronged him, hoping that a glimpse of their hero would inspire them further.

Dr. Kalam never shied away from reaching out to students, regardless of their backgrounds. He kept at it until the very end, collapsing when delivering a lecture at the Indian Institute of Management Shillong on July 27, 2015, before dying of a cardiac arrest.



PHOTOS: THE HINDU, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



ONE FOR THE MASSES

The turn of the century saw Dr. Kalam rise to the position of the head of state of the country. Both the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA) led by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the main opposition, the Indian National Congress, backed his candidacy, enabling him to become the country's 11th President on July 25, 2002. In the five years that followed, he not only worked well with the people around him — including Prime Ministers Atal Bihari Vajpayee (right in top) and Manmohan Singh (right in bottom) — but also made it a point to reach out to the public at large.

At the end of his tenure as the country's president, it came as no surprise to anyone who knew him that the 75-year-old had made it his life's objective — or what remained of it — to touch as many lives as he possibly could, especially those of children.

"One best book is equal to hundred good friends but one good friend is equal to a library

Dr. Abdul Kalam





20- MINUTE ACTIVITY FOR CHILDREN -1640

STUDENTS' DAY SPECIAL



GK Corner (3 mins)



Playing isn't just fun, it's actually a human right! International law explicitly guarantees children the right to rest, leisure, play, and participate in cultural and artistic activities. Which key international treaty specifically recognises a child's right to play and leisure? PHOTO: AFP

Ans: The UN Convention on the Rights of the Child, adopted in 1989.

Two-minute comprehension

Read the paragraphs below and answer the questions

The Odisha government on Tuesday approved free textbooks for around 28.7 lakh students of state-run schools, along with a ₹500-crore programme to improve urban drainage and tackle flooding. The decisions were among 16 proposals approved at a Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi here.

The proposals, relating to 11 departments, will be implemented soon, Chief Secretary Anu Garg told reporters after the meeting. The decision to provide free textbooks to more students comes amid a controversy over the supply of textbooks containing errors, with opposition parties demanding the resignation of School and Mass Education Minister Nityananda Gond. The scheme aims to ensure equitable access to quality education, reduce the financial burden on economically weaker families, improve enrolment in government schools, lower dropout rates and increase the transition from elementary to secondary education. The procurement of paper, printing, transportation and distribution of textbooks will be undertaken through a transparent and competitive process in accordance with the Odisha General Financial Rules and applicable procurement guidelines, she said. The School and Mass Education Department will put in place a mechanism to collect, verify and validate beneficiary data through field-level verification.

1) Which state government approved the distribution of free textbooks for students?

_____

2) What led to the decision to provide free textbooks?

_____

3) What does the scheme aim to provide?

_____

LIT-WIT IN TWO MINUTES

Guess the writer!



PHOTO: WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

1. You may know me as the writer of *Eragon*. But did you also know that I actually started writing the novel at the age of 15? _____

2. I am an author known for my Middle-Grade novels like *The Emperor's Riddle*. and my Amy Wu picture books. I started writing my first novel at the age of 12. _____

3. You know me as the writer of *Frankenstein*. But did you know that I came up with and began writing the story when I was 18 years old? _____

Answers: 1. Christopher Paolini, 2. Kat Zhang, 3. Mary Shelley

WORD BUILDER

How many words can you make with the letters in the word

UNIVERSITIES

_____ _____
_____ _____
_____ _____
_____ _____
_____ _____
_____ _____
_____ _____
_____ _____
_____ _____
_____ _____
_____ _____
_____ _____
_____ _____
_____ _____
_____ _____



Unscramble - in a minute

E	G	A	R	T	A	U	D

A noun, the word means a person who has finished their school, college or university education and has the respective degree.

Ans: Graduate

AMAZING ANAGRAMS

The following sentences are incomplete. In each, the missing word is the anagram of the highlighted word. See if you can figure it out!

1. One of the students who had studied throughout the **night**, could not remember a single _____ when he was writing the exam, due to lack of sleep.

2. Smiles _____ across the faces of students as the teacher had just **spared** them from homework.

3. One of the students, who _____ to become a scientist, was **praised** by the teacher for his good grades in the subject.

4. The students were cautioned on the _____ of stepping into the **garden** near the school's main gate, as there were reported sightings of snakes.

An **anagram** is a word or phrase that is formed by rearranging the letters of another.

Answers: 1. thing, 2. spread, 3. aspired, 4. danger

Word of the Day

- 2 minutes

DIPLOMA

Pronounced as: *duh-ploh-muh*

Meaning:

An official document or type of certification awarded by a college or university upon completing a course of study or graduating a programme.

Origin:

The word originates from Latin *diploma* meaning 'letter of recommendation' which further comes from Greek *diploma* meaning 'licence'.

Usage:

Natasha received her diploma in hotel management yesterday!

Activity:

Now, use the word in a sentence or two of your own.

_____
_____

Journal Writing

5 minutes

Dear Diary,

If I could create the class timetable, I would...

.....
.....
.....
.....
.....
.....
.....
.....

MINI QUIZ 2 mins...

Today's quiz is on student change makers

1) Which teenage environmental activist from Sweden inspired the climate movement called Fridays for Future?

2) Which student from Tamil Nadu developed the world's smallest satellite called Kalamsat?

3) Who founded the Ocean Cleanup project in 2013?

4) Which climate movement was founded by Ugandan activist Vanessa Nakate?

5) Who founded Project Jeans, which upcycles old denim into insulated winter sleeping bags for street dwellers?

PHOTO : R. RAVINDRAN/THE HINDU



Answers: 1) Greta Thunberg 2) Rifath Sharook 3) Boyan Slat 4) Rise Up Climate Movement 5) Nivaan Somany

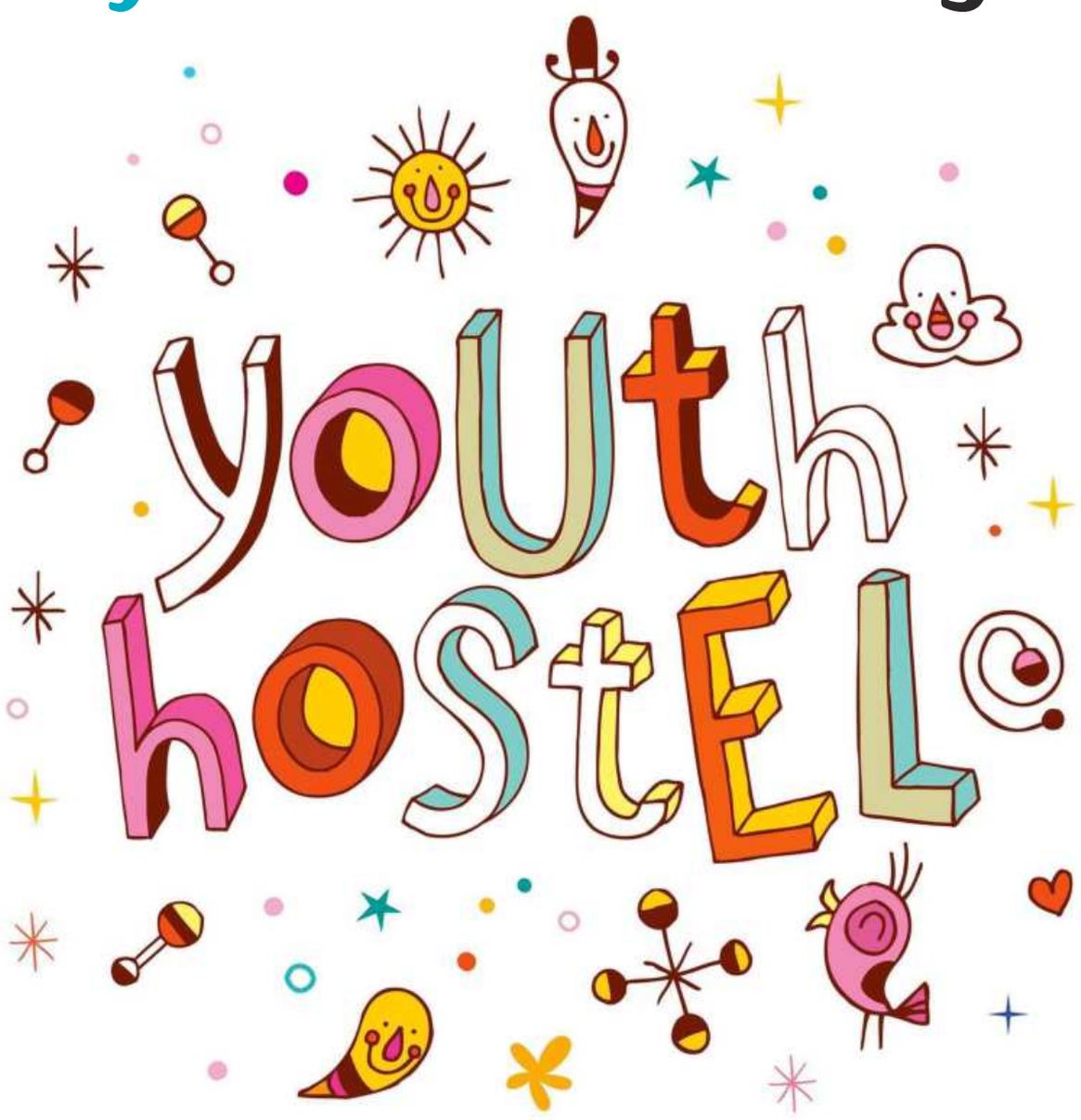
In how many minutes did you complete today's activities?



The Hostel life: More than being away from home

Though college itself is a memorable experience, adding hostel life to that makes it extra special.

Malini Murugan



Life is a museum of experiences. Some are sweet, some are bitter, and some are bittersweet. No two experiences will be the exact same, nor will they evoke the same feeling. And one such bittersweet experience is hostel life. Students usually stay in hostels at college, as they go to a different city, state, or country to pursue their interests. Though college itself is a memorable experience, adding hostel life to that makes it extra special. You may enter alone, nervous and scared, but leave confidently with friends who will stay with you for the rest of your life.

Homesickness

The first big challenge when staying in a hostel is homesickness. You will crave the familiarity of your own room and the company of people you have known your entire life. Now, there are many rules imposed on what time you need to go to bed or when you have to eat. So, the urge to leave and seek a place of comfort will be immense, but it is important to stay back. It will take some time to get used to it, but eventually you will. Leyah Susanna Thomas, 20, who is currently living in a hostel, said: "It might take six days or six weeks or six months, but you will be able to adapt to it, and will start enjoying the process of being alone." After this initial period, you might get used to the hostel way of life so much that going home will make you feel like you are just a guest staying over at your own home, says Harini S, 21.

The first big challenge when staying in a hostel is homesickness.



The journey to self-discovery

When you are by yourself, you learn many things about yourself. All the inhibitions that you would have had back home disappear. For Leyah, she thought she would be spending her 'college life in a corner quietly', but she actually stepped up for roles and took part in various college events. It was the same with Darshan, who thought he would only be doing football, but then discovered he was actually a good dancer. He says, "I never thought I would get up on the stage to dance." Being away from home allows you to explore yourself and get to know yourself better. It might be overwhelming at first, but it will become easier once you are used to it.

"If you are very picky with food, then hostel food is not for you."

The one thing that movies got right, like reality, other than lifelong friendships, even from 1995, is that the food is bad. The food is described as stale and watery, and repetitive. The menu does not change, and eating the same dishes week after week is monotonous. The stereotype of losing weight when you join a hostel is true. Darshan says that it happened like everyone said it would. Though survival might be difficult initially, Leyah says, at one point you will get accustomed to it.



Overall, staying in a hostel comes with many rules and difficulties; it might even include a few mental breakdowns in the beginning, but once you find dependable friends and are confident in your own abilities, you will be able to manage anything that comes your way. Movies like "3 Idiots" show fun friendships which last a lifetime, and that is true. But keep in mind that expectation cannot be placed on all such relationships; some remain just as batch mates, and that too is okay. Ultimately, staying away from home at a hostel is a special experience and getting to enjoy that is truly a blessing in disguise.

(The author was an intern with The Hindu In School.)



The joy of independence

Although there are many rules at the hostel, and it feels restrictive, a significant amount of freedom is also gained. In Leyah's hostel, for example, there are curfews for bathing time. So, living in the hostel might not exactly make you feel free, but it will give you the freedom to make your own choices for yourself. At home or at school, you are not really allowed to make many decisions for yourself. However, when you are away from all of that, you are free to make your own choices on what you want to eat and where you want to go out. Of course, staying safe is also important during those times. And there might be embarrassing situations if you are in a new place, like taking the wrong bus or getting on the wrong train compartment, as Harini recalls, but these are fond memories of her own growth. Krishna Prema K, 51, says that she would wake up early during the weekends and explore the city when she used to be in a hostel back in 1995. Gaining autonomy during our teenage years will make us confident in ourselves and the decisions we take. It will feel freeing and happy as now you know how to interact with people and navigate places independently.

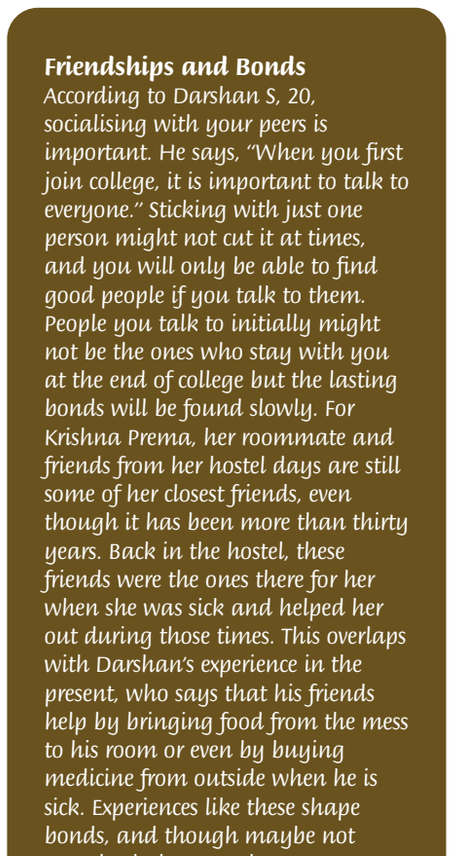
Not-so-scary seniors

Though they might be portrayed as scary in movies, in reality, they aren't often like that. Seniors are very great friends and mentors who can guide you through college life. For Leyah, some of her seniors are her closest friends from college. It is important to remember that they, too, were freshers once and would be able to help you better than anyone else. Darshan says they are almost like teachers who help him in academics as well as in other things. While being on the same topic as seniors, bullying and ragging by them is banned everywhere. Colleges have special Anti-ragging cells, and they are there for student welfare. So, it is not prevalent today as much as it was before, and there are strict rules regarding it. For example, in Darshan's college, just mentioning the word 'ragging' might get you suspended. Even with all these rules, if someone does try to rag juniors, it is essential to inform a trusted adult and protect yourself from further harm.

Friendships and Bonds

According to Darshan S, 20, socialising with your peers is important. He says, "When you first join college, it is important to talk to everyone." Sticking with just one person might not cut it at times, and you will only be able to find good people if you talk to them. People you talk to initially might not be the ones who stay with you at the end of college but the lasting bonds will be found slowly. For Krishna Prema, her roommate and friends from her hostel days are still some of her closest friends, even though it has been more than thirty years. Back in the hostel, these friends were the ones there for her when she was sick and helped her out during those times. This overlaps with Darshan's experience in the present, who says that his friends help by bringing food from the mess to his room or even by buying medicine from outside when he is sick. Experiences like these shape bonds, and though maybe not completely happy when you are sick, it is sweet. And these friends do not necessarily even have to be from your own class or batch; seniors, too, make great friends.

PHOTOS: UNSPLASH IMAGES, THE HINDU, ISTOCKPHOTO



THE HINDU
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Gaining autonomy during our teenage years will make us confident in ourselves and the decisions we take. It will feel freeing and happy as now you know how to interact with people and navigate places independently.

LIVE TO LEARN
LEARN TO LIVE



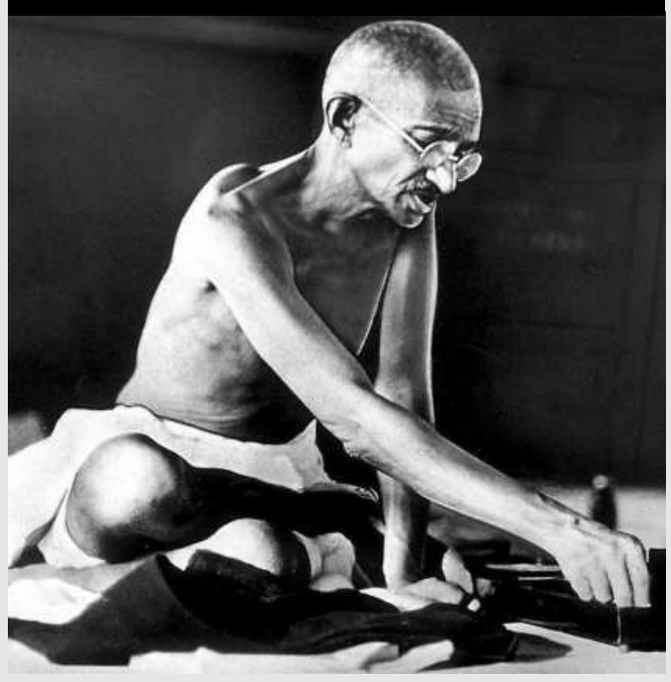
"Learning gives creativity, creativity leads to thinking, thinking provides knowledge, knowledge makes you great.
A.P.J. ABDUL KALAM



"When girls are educated, their countries become stronger and more prosperous.
MICHELLE OBAMA

PHOTOS: GETTY IMAGES, REUTERS, AFP, AP, THE HINDU

"By education, I mean an all-round drawing out of the best in child and man — body, mind and spirit. Literacy is not the end of education nor even the beginning. It is only one of the means whereby man and woman can be educated. Literacy in itself is no education.
MAHATMA GANDHI





"Let us pick up our books and our pens. They are our most powerful weapons. One teacher, one book, one pen, can change the world.
MALALA YOUSAFZAI

"The highest result of education is tolerance.
HELEN KELLER

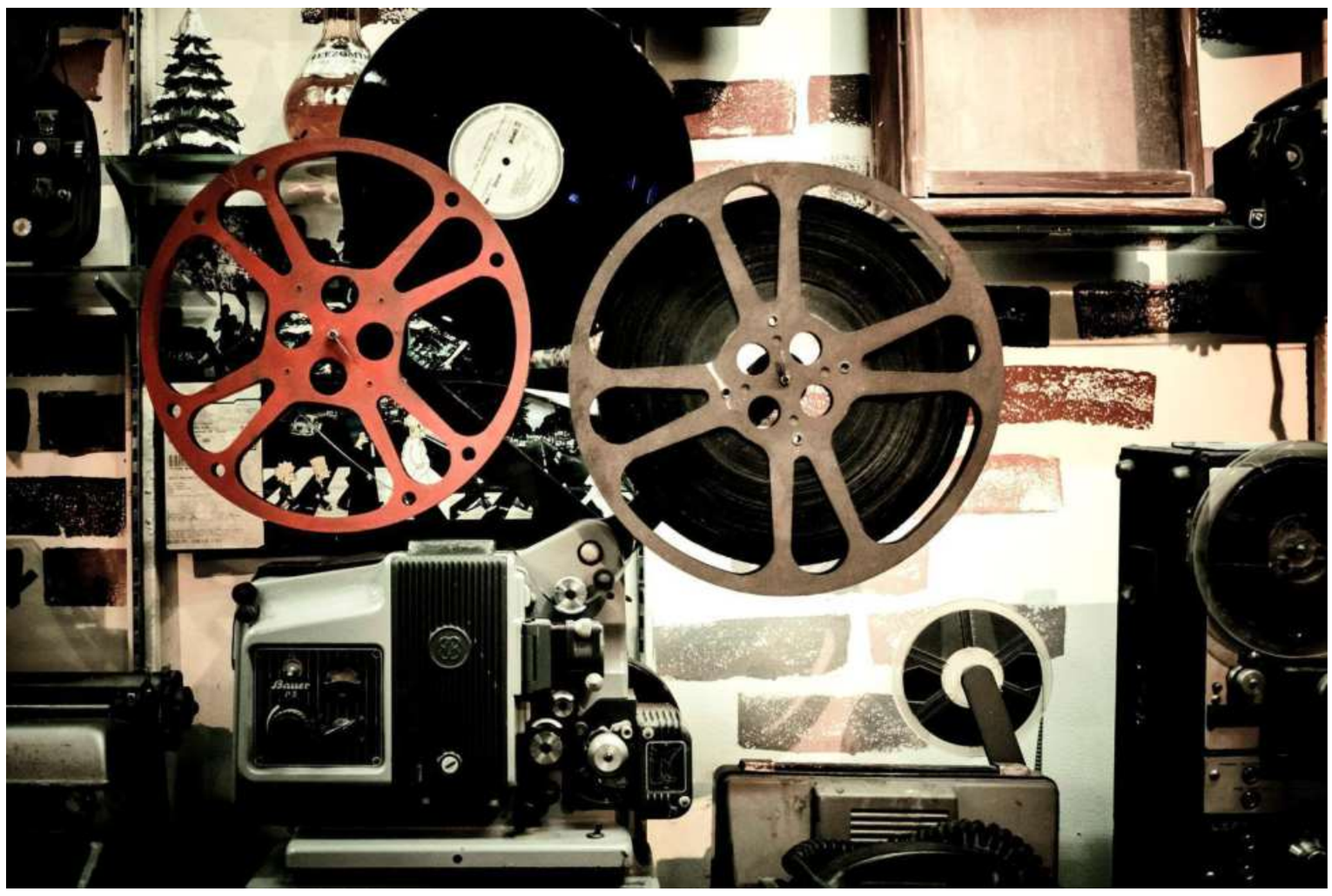


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LIFETIME STUDENTS OF CINEMA

"I like unformed characters. This may be because, no matter how old I get, I am still unformed myself," iconic filmmaker Akira Kurosawa wrote in his autobiography. Many established filmmakers considered themselves to be students of cinema, even when they were at the peak of their career. Here, we look at movies and makers around this theme...

Rudrangsh Gupta



REPRESENTATIVE IMAGES: MAGNIFIC / UNSPLASH

Adapting Indian folk traditions

Sunflowers were the First Ones to Know | Chidananda S. Naik | On YouTube



When Chidananda Naik's (in picture) *'Sunflowers were the First Ones to Know'* won the La Cinef prize at the Cannes Film Festival a few years ago, it was a moment of celebration for all of Indian cinema altogether, and of course, the arrival of a new voice. When I watched the film, I found myself admiring the astute language that the camera possessed throughout the story. Chidananda manages to intertwine a folk story into the cinematic medium which becomes as dreamlike as it is elemental. Narrated by a protagonist whose grandmother steals a village rooster that causes the sun to never rise again, the absence of light allows for fire to take over, create an orange-blue hue and a pre-dominant nightscape where time begins to slowly dissolve, until it is not just the villagers, but us as a viewer who have no understanding of what time it is. Naik then begins to introduce a journey to find the grandmother, through which the film arrives at what is a nightmare and dream at once.

The writing (entirely a Kannada film) is deeply profound, and the performances are restrained. The soundscape of the film is also worth noting, which feels atmospheric and ever so unique. The film itself feels inspiring to achieve a unique visual sense that expands the endless possibilities of cinema itself. One can question the many ways to arrive at how to show a story, and that is what sets *'Sunflowers were the First Ones to Know'* apart. It reminded me of the works of Amit Dutta (*Nainsukh, Kshya Tra Ghya*), another exponent of the Film and Television Institute of India, whose capturing of the Indian aesthetic is masterful. In what ways can we bring forth the various storytelling traditions that are prevalent around the country into the form of cinema? How does one adapt the oral folk tradition, or a certain subsect of painting into the medium of cinema, whose pre-dominant concerns are with space and time? Maybe, if we question these, and attempt to study our ancient texts and traditions, and try to find ways to translate them on screen, we can challenge and broaden the limits of cinema.

The sound of 'progress'

Girni (2004) | Umesh Kulkarni | On YouTube



From the opening shot itself, Umesh Kulkarni's (in picture) gripping student diploma film made at the Film and Television Institute of India sucks you into its distinct setting that feels all too real. The narrative follows how the arrival of a Girni changes the life of a young boy, for worse.

The manner in which the camera moves is remarkable throughout the film, and the use of sound marks the mastery of technique. It is in the absence of dialogue where *'Girni'* thrives, in its mechanical haunting soundscape that wrings the ears and completely isolates the protagonist. The story also captures a secondary narrative of a woman who tries to find her own footing after the loss of her husband, and thus, the film delves into a more complex narrative altogether.

Umesh Kulkarni never forces you to connect the dots of the arrival of the machine, a necessity for their family's livelihood, and the boy's subsequent madness and isolation to any metaphor in particular. One can of course, see the film from the lens of the arrival of industrialisation and an advent of capitalism, the man against the machine, but it is the intensity with which Kulkarni approaches his twenty-two minute film that is truly remarkable. It was the sign of the arrival of a new powerful voice in the face of Indian cinema, and a truly seminal work that is till date celebrated across film schools and film students in the country.

PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Capturing storytelling in India

1.2 (2011) | Prantik Narayan Basu | On YouTube

Another film that finds itself attempting to capture the oral storytelling tradition that exists in India, *'1.2'* is not a diploma film project but in fact a ten-minute dialogue exercise film made entirely in a studio by Prantik Narayanan Basu (in picture) during his time at the Film and Television Institute of India. However, upon watching it, one may find themselves scratching their heads realising that everything in the film is entirely a set. It is an amalgamation of effort, and what it translates to is a work that transports a viewer to a very specific world that the filmmaker attempts to create.

Two stories take place over the course of the film, and both



have a common link between them. The blue, rustic stained look of the film creates a sense of mysticism. It is not necessarily an easy film to understand, but nonetheless, a film that also manages to use music in its dialogue as an extremely powerful device. The use of music further creates irony too, and the choice of the music being in a language different to the rest of the film, which is in Hindi, also must be brought to notice.

Every time I watch this film, I find myself in awe of the surety of the filmmaker. It seems to be made with a sense of pure precision and a deep understanding of the craft. There is something extremely unique in the way it connects its stories together, where both stories, albeit about a common character, almost never feel like they are about the same person, yet have the essence of the same person throughout.



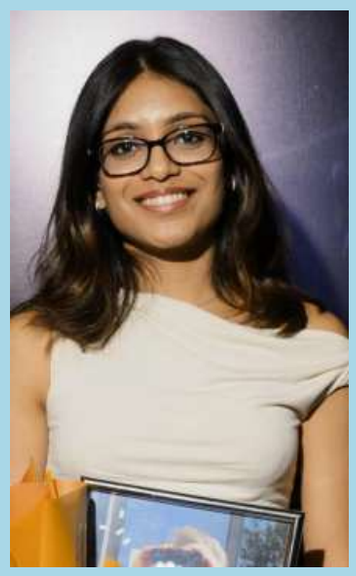
The art of rural realism

Bali (2026) | Amoli Birewar



Amoli Birewar's deeply observational documentary, *'Bali'* captures characters almost as though you are right next to them, along with them in their journeys and exploits. It is a poignant film that feels both hopeful yet deeply saddening, the result is a tender and emotional human drama. You are almost instantly connected with the characters, and their individual stories. The evening solitude gives a feeling of a nearing end, and rightfully so, for the three friends are about to finish their years of schooling and move ahead in their lives. Perhaps, they may no longer be able to spend the time that they have with each other. They aspire to play kabaddi for India, but their families want them to be married off.

I remember watching Amoli's student diploma film a few years ago, a poignant, near-hour long expose on the "feeling of



home" of college students who live in apartments on rent during their course. Amoli has a stunning power to capture human beings in their most natural state. They may be aware of the camera's presence, but it never feels that way to the audience. This owes to the way she is able to interact with her social actors off the camera. She remains honest with her process, and does not hesitate to be honest and vulnerable about her process before rolling the camera. Along with this comes hard work in the form of sleepless nights of transcribing and pre-planning for the next day's shoot.

In a recent conversation with the filmmaker, whose film *'Bali'* is one of the first of surely many great works that will emerge from her side, Amoli revealed much about her process, especially how important it was for her to make sure that her characters were extremely comfortable not just with the presence of the camera, but the crew too. Her fly on the wall style of documentary also has some brilliantly shot sequences of kabaddi being played during a competition. This, juxtaposed with the personal lives of her protagonist create a tension and conflict that was always naturally present from the day she heard about this story, that unfolds in her ancestral village in Maharashtra. Shot with a modest crew of just her and two other cinematographers who were present at different times, she describes the shooting of the kabaddi sequence as a little dance that was orchestrated instinctively with time, and one can indeed sense the rhythm of dance in the sequence.

Amoli Birewar's work is inspiring as a whole, not just in the film that she has made but the wonderful human collaboration throughout it all. Her tender human observation is proof that she is a filmmaker with a fresh voice and one to watch out for. *(The author is a freelance contributor.)*

Student life of a homeschooled child

A path of education where learning is made flexible, and subjects come from choice. G Nayanakshatra shares her story as a student at NIOS and the lessons she learnt along the way.

G Nayanakshatra



PHOTOS: AI-GENERATED IMAGE, MAGNIFIC

I never imagined that my 11th and 12th grades would be different from regular school. Like everyone, I thought I would continue classes with the same routine of wearing a uniform, attending lessons, meeting friends every day, and waiting for the final bell to ring. But one unexpected situation changed everything and introduced me to NIOS.

A new path

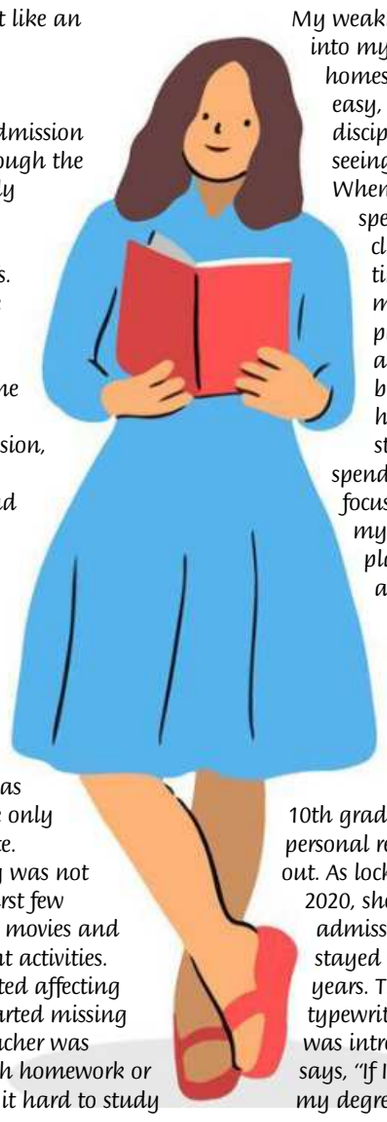
I missed my 11th-grade mid-term exam due to personal reasons. Soon after that, my school informed me that I would not be allowed to continue to the next term and would have to repeat the academic year. Hearing that was heartbreaking. The thought of watching my friends move ahead while I stayed back to repeat the year with my juniors was devastating.

I started looking for other options. Initially, my parents suggested that I move to a different school, but I was not ready to leave everything behind and start fresh in a new environment. So, I continued searching for alternatives and eventually came across the National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS). I then remembered one of my school friends who had shifted to the NIOS board in our school in 9th grade. After speaking with her, I got to know that I could directly attend my senior secondary (12th) without repeating the year. At that moment, NIOS felt like an eye-opener to me.

Entering NIOS

I completed the admission process online through the NIOS portal. It only required my 10th marksheet and a few identity proofs. In NIOS, I had the freedom to choose subjects, a study centre, and even the exam centre. Two weeks after admission, the books arrived through post. I had one and a half years left for my examination. I first started by completing the Tutor Marked Assignment because I saw the submission date approaching. It was easy and took me only a week to complete.

Homeschooling was not easy. I spent the first few months watching movies and trying out different activities. Eventually, it started affecting me mentally. I started missing my friends; no teacher was pressuring me with homework or tests, and I found it hard to study regularly. I did not feel productive and constantly worried if I had made the wrong decision.



Growth and strength

My weakness slowly turned into my strength. Yes, homeschooling was not easy, but it taught me discipline. I slowly started seeing the positive side. When I went to school, I spent half the day in class, where I spent less time studying and more time talking, playing with friends, and waiting for the bell to ring. As a homeschooled student, I was able to spend my entire day focusing on improving myself. I started planning my day and actually followed it.

Ms. Nithyashree, an NIOS student whom I had met in college, also shares a similar story. She studied in matriculation till 10th grade, but due to personal reasons, she dropped out. As lockdown began in 2020, she was unable to find admission in a school and stayed at home for two years. Through her typewriting class teacher, she was introduced to NIOS. She says, "If I'm here today doing my degree, it's all because I studied in NIOS. If not for NIOS, I don't think I would have completed my 12th and be doing my degree today."

NIOS can be done in two ways — either as a homeschooled student or by choosing the NIOS board at a school. Ms. Sankritha Krishnakumar, a student who studied under the NIOS board at school, says, "As an NIOS student, I had the privilege to choose (the) subjects of my choice. I wanted to take up an arts group, especially Mass Communication, as my core subject. When I failed to get that option, one of my relatives suggested that I try NIOS. My schooling experience with NIOS was smooth, and it helped me choose subjects which I wanted to pursue at the college level. My main subject, Mass Communication, helped me understand traditional and digital media, along with how print, radio, and television operate. Psychology helped me understand human behaviour and how it is shaped."

Students and teachers

As a homeschooled student, I did not have much of a student-teacher relationship. Through the PCP [Personal Contact Programme] provided by NIOS, I went to the study centre on scheduled dates and cleared my doubts with teachers. Ms. Chandra, an NIOS student who studied the NIOS board at school, says, "As an NIOS student in Omega School, I had a flexible schedule for my extracurricular activities. My teachers guided me to make the right decisions. It was great to be part of NIOS. I don't know if students from CBSE or IGCSE can speak freely to their teachers, but in NIOS, teachers and students are close to each other. My teachers supported me when no one believed I would pass my 10th grade. My Economics teacher motivated and supported me throughout my board exams. I am very grateful to my teachers and friends for being part of my NIOS journey."

In March/April 2023, I successfully wrote my NIOS examinations at the same time as my school friends. I started NIOS with so much fear and confusion, but eventually learnt a lot and felt extremely proud of myself for getting through it all.

The results were declared in June, and I started looking for colleges. The college I wanted admission to was under Madras University, and they asked for a provisional eligibility certificate from the university. I applied for it with the required documents, received it within a month, submitted it to the college, and got admission. All NIOS students were required to submit this certificate, even though NIOS is a nationally recognised board.

Doing my senior secondary education through NIOS is something I will never regret. NIOS is a board that not many people are aware of — a board that does not put unnecessary pressure on students. Choosing subjects they like, studying at their own pace, and having flexible exam dates are everything a student would ask for, and that is exactly what NIOS offers.

(The author was an intern with The Hindu In School)



> **"Choosing subjects they like, studying at their own pace, and having flexible exam dates are everything a student would ask for, and that is exactly what NIOS offers."**

NIOS FAQ

What is NIOS, and who can apply for it?

The National Institute of Open Schooling is a government-recognised board that has offered open and distance learning opportunities in India since 1989. It is for learners who cannot continue regular schooling because of work commitments, health issues, financial limitations, sports, or personal circumstances.

How does studying through NIOS work?

NIOS allows students to learn independently using study materials prepared by the board. After enrolment, learners receive printed textbooks and can also access digital resources online. This system gives students the freedom to study according to their own schedule and pace.

What subjects and examination options are available in NIOS?

For both Secondary and Senior Secondary courses, students are required to select a minimum of five subjects and may choose up to seven. Exams are generally conducted twice each year. In addition, NIOS provides an On Demand Examination facility, enabling students to take exams whenever they feel ready.

What are TMAs and why do they matter?

Tutor Marked Assignments are handwritten assignments that contribute to internal assessment marks. They account for 20% of the overall theory score and help students maintain consistent study habits throughout the academic session.

Is the NIOS certificate accepted for higher studies and employment?

Yes. NIOS is officially recognised in India, and its certificates are accepted for admission to colleges, competitive examinations, and various government and private-sector jobs, similar to certificates issued by other recognised education boards.

LIVE TO LEARN, LEARN TO LIVE



> **"The chief aim of education should be to help the growing soul to draw out that in itself which is best and make it perfect for a noble use."**
> - SRI AUROBINDO

> **"The education and empowerment of women throughout the world cannot fail to result in a more caring, tolerant, just and peaceful life for all.**
> - AUNG SAN SUU KYI

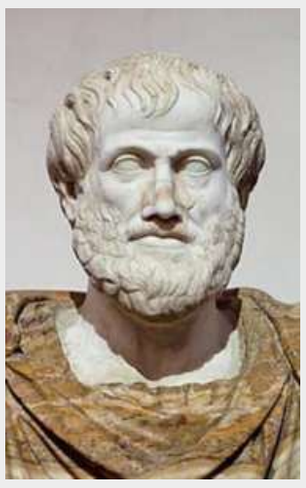




> **"A woman without education is like a banyan tree without roots or leaves; she cannot provide for her children and stay alive herself.**
> - SAVITRIBAI PHULE



> **"We want the education by which character is formed, strength of mind is increased, the intellect is expanded, and by which one can stand on one's own feet.**
> - SWAMI VIVEKANANDA



> **"The roots of education are bitter, but the fruit is sweet.**
> - ARISTOTLE

PHOTOS: THE HINDU, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT, WIKIMEDIA COMMONS, AFP



A.P.J. Abdul Kalam answering questions from students.

WORKOUTABLES
A PGG QUIZ

THE KALAM CODE

Every year, World Students Day is celebrated in India on October 15, marking the birth of Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam. Here is a quiz on the life and times of the Missile Man of India. Get started!

1 In 1963, X sent a 7-member team, including Dr. Kalam, to NASA to learn about rocket technology. X is known as the founding father of India's space program and ISRO's lead facility is named after him. Who is X?



A painting depicting Indian rocket warfare in the 18th Century.

2 While visiting a facility belonging to NASA, Dr. Kalam was amazed by a painting on the wall. It depicted an 18th Century Indian king firing iron-cased military rockets against the British army, leaving Dr. Kalam awestruck. Who was this historical ruler who was also known as the Tiger of Mysore? _____

3 Dr. Kalam would go on to spearhead India's defence programme that developed missiles "Prithvi" and X. X would continue to be a common theme in his most famous writings - his autobiography and another book aimed at creating a spark in young children. What is X and what are the book titles?

4 When Dr. Kalam was heading the DRDO, he became interested in finding civilian applications for technology originally developed for defence. When he learnt from Dr. Soma Raju that a vital medical device was extremely expensive in India because it had to be imported, Dr. Kalam set about developing an indigenous version using DRDO's expertise in materials engineering. The resulting version, made of refined stainless steel, was strong enough while permitting blood flow. It cost less than a quarter of imported versions. What device, vital in heart operations today, is this that carries the name Kalam-Raju ___ even today?



5 In 1958, Dr. Kalam narrowly missed the merit list to become an Indian Air Force pilot. But 48 years later, in 2006, as the President of India, he undertook a flight sitting in the rear cockpit of the fighter plane Sukhoi Su-30 MKI. While on this flight, he became the first Indian President to experience or achieve what?

6 During the Pokhran nuclear tests, Dr. Kalam was given a false military identity as scientists repeatedly arriving at an Army test range would attract attention. The codename by which Dr. Kalam was known during his visits was an interesting coincidence as Pakistan had only recently developed its Ghauri missile, named after Muhammad of Ghor, and the name which Dr. Kalam assumed was that of a Rajput ruler who had fought Muhammad of Ghor. What was Dr. Kalam's code name?

7 What connects this exhaustive list?



S Radhakrishnan (1954)

Rajendra Prasad (1962)

Zakir Hussain (1963)

V Giri (1975)

Abdul Kalam (1997)

Pranab Mukherjee (2019)

PHOTOS: THE HINDU ARCHIVES, PTI, WIKIMEDIA COMMONS, AFP, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

8 *Solibacillus Kalamii* is a rod-shaped bacteria that was isolated from the HEPA filter, a routine housekeeping, cleaning and air filter system, used on the X. It was named in honour of Dr. Kalam. The bacteria has the ability to withstand intense radiation and the filter on which the bug was found was aboard for over 40 months. What is X or where is the filter used?

9 Dr. Kalam, before he became famous for leading India's missile program, was tasked with a project to develop India's first indigenous hovercraft. As he was not experienced in the topic, Dr. Kalam approached experts at IISc to develop the appropriate propeller type and successfully led the project to completion, delivering a working prototype ahead of schedule. What was the name of this project? It shares its name with a divine vehicle or *vahana*. _____



10 Earlier this year, IIM Shillong unveiled this life-sized statue of Dr. Kalam to commemorate what event that occurred 11 years ago at the same campus?

Answers
1 Dr. Vikram Sarabhai
2 Tipu Sultan
3 *Agni, Wings of Fire* and *Ignited Minds*
4 Stent
5 Break the sound barrier
6 Prithviraj
7 Only presidents with a Bharat Ratna. The year in brackets is the year in which they won the Bharat Ratna.
8 Aboard the International Space Station
9 Nandi
10 Dr. Kalam passed away following a cardiac arrest while delivering a talk at IIM Shillong.

STUDENT LETTERS

To ma'am, with love

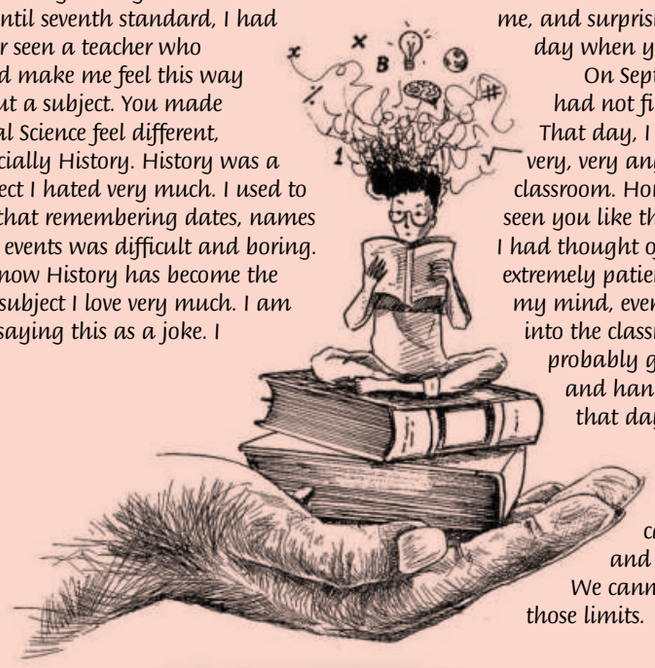
V. S. Nithyasri writes a letter to her teacher reminiscing the lessons she gave beyond books and the walls of a classroom...

Dear Padhma Priya ma'am,

Some teachers teach a subject, but some teachers change the way we see that subject. You are one of those teachers in my life. You not only teach our lessons well, but you also share your own stories with us. Some stories make us laugh, some inspire us, and make us think deeply.

Until my seventh standard, whenever the Social Science period came, the first thought in my mind was, "Oh my God, Social Science! Okay, ready to sleep!" That was honestly how I felt. But in eighth standard, Social Science became interesting to me. Whenever the Social Science period comes, my face gets brighter, my lips stretch into a broad smile, my eyes shine in the daylight, my ears become sharper, and my brain becomes more attentive. It is not simply because of Social Science. It is because of the way you teach it. Your way of teaching is truly awesome.

Until seventh standard, I had never seen a teacher who could make me feel this way about a subject. You made Social Science feel different, especially History. History was a subject I hated very much. I used to feel that remembering dates, names and events was difficult and boring. But now History has become the one subject I love very much. I am not saying this as a joke. I really mean it. You made me look at the subject with different eyes.



I have no perfect words to express what I feel about you, but I still want to try. You are not just a teacher to me. You are like an angel in my school life. You always encourage me to become a more successful person in life. You always believe in me. You encouraged me to publish books and to continue writing stories, novels and poems. You encouraged me to work hard and aim to become the first-mark student among all the classes.

Whenever I achieve success in a competition, you are one of the first people I want to tell. It is because I know that you will be genuinely happy for me. Your encouragement makes my achievements feel even more special.

Life lessons

There is one more thing you have taught me, and surprisingly, it came from a day when you were angry.

On September 1, our class had not finished our classwork. That day, I saw you become very, very angry, and you left our classroom. Honestly, I had never seen you like that before. Until then, I had thought of you as an extremely patient and soft person. In my mind, even if a storm came into the classroom, you would probably give a small smile and handle it calmly! But that day, I understood something important: even a very patient person can become angry, and everyone has limits. We cannot keep crossing those limits.

But it was also a meaningful lesson. Patience does not mean accepting everything. Sometimes, people become angry because something has gone beyond their limit. We should understand that and learn to correct ourselves.

Then came September 2. You returned to our classroom with a bright face and calmly asked us why we had not completed the work. You did not shout a single word. I was surprised. I almost froze because I had expected you to be angry again. Instead, you spoke normally and continued the class.

That moment taught me even more about patience. If I had been in your place, I might have shouted, cried out or completely lost my patience. But you handled the situation calmly. It showed me that being patient is not about never becoming angry. It is about knowing how to control ourselves after a difficult moment. To me, learning is not only about lessons, marks or examinations. It is also about carrying those lessons into our lives. You have taught me many things that will never be written on a blackboard.

A thank you note

If I had to choose a thing I want to thank you for the most, I would choose your belief in me. Thank you for teaching me patience, encouraging. motivating, and believing in my abilities. Sometimes, a student needs someone to believe in them before they learn to believe in themselves. You have been that person for me.

One day, I may forget some History dates, names or answers. I may even forget some chapters from my textbooks. But I do not think I will forget the teacher who made my face brighten when Social Science appeared on my timetable.

Ma'am, you did not simply teach me Social Science. You changed the way I saw it. You turned my least favourite subject into one of my favourite subjects. You encouraged my writing, supported my dreams and taught me patience through your own actions.

Thank you for being a teacher who does more than teach.

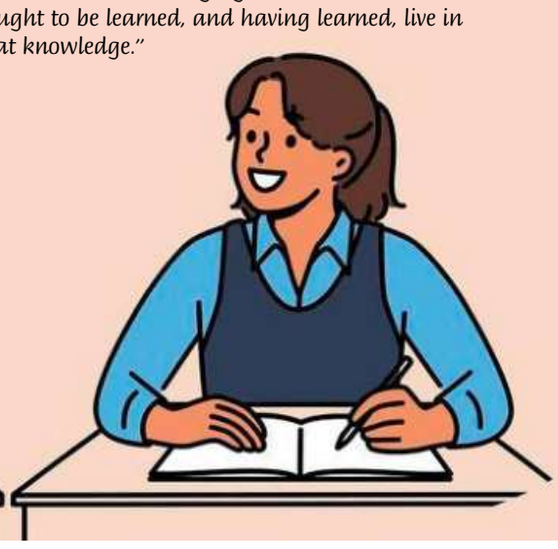
With heartfelt gratitude,
V. S. Nithyasri

(The writer is a class 8 student from Cuddalore, Tamil Nadu.)



"கற்க கசடறக் கற்பவை கற்றபின்
நிற்க அதற்குத் தக."

The above couplet is from *Thirukkural*, a classical Tamil poetic text made up of 1,330 short couplets (two-line poems called kurals) written by the poet Thiruvalluvar. It roughly translates, "Learn thoroughly what ought to be learned, and having learned, live in accordance with that knowledge."



Dear future ME!

From friendships to discovering a love for theatre, Avnika Rana writes a letter to herself on how her schools shaped her interests while giving her some unforgettable good memories to cherish

Dear me,

Student life is not just about exams and marks — it is about the chaos, friendships, lessons, and rare distractions that shape who we are. As I write this, I want to capture the essence of my journey, the reflections that go beyond classrooms.

At my first school, my days were filled with group projects that were anything but calm. Imagine ten students shouting ideas at once, glue spilling on charts, someone forgetting the main file at home, and another trying to act like the "boss." It was pure chaos, yet somehow we always managed to finish. Those moments taught me patience and teamwork, but more importantly, they taught me leadership. It showed me that true leaders are not those who collect followers, but those who inspire others to lead. I learned that guiding a team is not about control — it is about encouragement. And in that noisy classroom, I realised that leadership is born in the middle of chaos, not silence.

The friendships at my first school were equally unforgettable. My friends there were not just classmates; they were like guardians, sometimes even like parents — protecting me, guiding me, and standing by me in ways that felt genuine. They were never the "fake and snake type" bonds that sometimes appear in student life. Those friendships gave me a sense of belonging that still warms my heart. It taught me loyalty, trust, and the value of standing together, and those lessons remain with me even today.



PHOTOS: GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO, UNSPLASH, THE HINDU

The second chapter

Moving to my second school opened a new chapter. Here, I finally discovered something I can proudly call a hobby — theatre. Standing on stage, rehearsing lines, and feeling the spotlight taught me courage and expression. Theatre became more than an activity; it became a mirror to my emotions and a channel for creativity. The school also gave me exposure that pushed me beyond my comfort zone. This time, I don't have the distractions of smartphones or endless chatter with friends. Instead, I face a rarer distraction: the pull of opportunities themselves. With so much exposure, it is easy to feel scattered, but I remind myself that focus is the key to growth.

Both schools shaped me in different ways. Together, they helped me become a pioneer — someone who does not just follow the path but tries to create one. I realise now that student life is not about choosing between academics and hobbies, or between old friends and new opportunities. It is about weaving them together into a story that is uniquely mine.

Of course, student life also has its funny side. I still laugh when I remember the day our group project chart fell off the wall during a presentation, and instead of panicking, one of my friends started improvising with hand gestures as if he were the chart himself. The teacher couldn't stop smiling, and we ended up getting extra marks for "creativity." Moments like these remind me that laughter is as important as learning, and sometimes mistakes turn into memories we cherish forever.

Personal lessons

Beyond school walls, student life has also taught me personal lessons. I have learned that growth often comes from discomfort — whether it is the chaos of a group project, the fear before stepping on stage, or the challenge of balancing responsibilities. I have learned that distractions are not always negative; sometimes they are opportunities in disguise. And I have learned that true strength lies not in perfection but in resilience — the ability to stumble, rise, and keep moving forward.

As I reflect, I see student life as a gift. It is a time when friendships feel pure, when opportunities feel endless, and when every mistake is a lesson. It is a time when schools become more than institutions — they become homes, shaping us into leaders, dreamers, and pioneers.

So, dear future me, when you read this letter years later, I hope you smile at the memories of both schools — the guardianship of old friends, the hustle of projects, the thrill of theatre, and the exposure that shaped you. Remember that being a student was not about chasing perfection but about embracing growth, courage, and compassion. Remember that you were not just a follower, but someone who inspired others. And remember that these lessons will stay with you long after the classrooms fade.

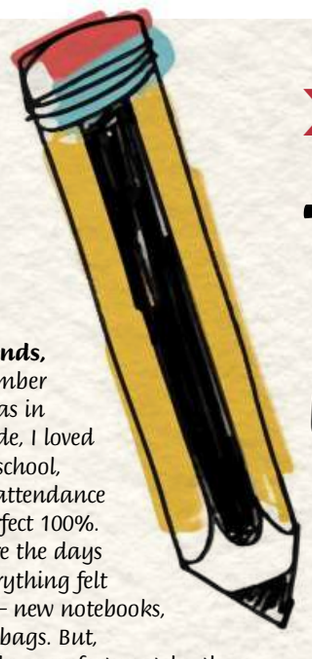
With gratitude and hope,
Avnika Rana

(The writer is a class 9 student from Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh.)



STUDENT LETTERS

The good, the bad and the bunking



Dear friends,

I remember when I was in third grade, I loved going to school, and my attendance was a perfect 100%. Those were the days when everything felt exciting — new notebooks, colourful bags. But, fortunately or unfortunately, there was a dramatic change when I reached Class 11, as I found myself in a position where I felt school was a bit annoying! Waking up at a sharp 6:30, standing on the ground for the assembly where the sun was as bright as it could be and I was as drained as I could be, then coming back from school at 2 p.m., highly exhausted. The uniform felt heavier, the homework felt endless, and the days somehow seemed longer. Yet still, there was a reason to attend school, and that reason was basically my hilarious friends and their dumb acts — like bunking PT period because of the march past, bunking activity classes to play sports, or just bunking around for no reason at all.

We bunked the PT period as we believed that there would be a march-past practice, and unfortunately, our PT teacher spotted us. The moment he started walking toward our corner, one of you took off running and the rest of us followed without a second thought. Our hearts were racing faster than our legs, and for a few seconds it genuinely felt like we were playing Subway Surfers right in the middle of school.

So basically, we were all running, and our PT teacher was chasing after us like it was an official race. At a certain point, one of my friends was running so blindly that she was eventually caught by the PT teacher first; then the rest of us surrendered, as it was the goal of loyal friendship. We stood there panting, trying to look innocent while failing miserably. One of the hilarious parts was that our computer teacher questioned us with genuine curiosity: "Why did we run from this side? We could have escaped from the other area." And we tried not to laugh in her face because she was calmly suggesting ways for us to bunk successfully. That moment still makes me smile every time I think about it.

Mangoes, mayhem and memories

There are a lot of things we did besides this one. One was climbing through the sister's garden after school to get some raw mangoes. I legitimately stepped on the railing and stripped one or two raw mangoes from the tree, while my friend stood behind commenting like a full comic comedian, giving live commentary as if it were a sports match. Additionally, we made *bhelpuri* in the class, mixing all the ingredients we had and somehow the result was surprisingly good. We threw water on each other near the water tank until our uniforms were soaked, ridiculously played football so carelessly that one of you would lose balance and hit the ground, and instead of helping, we would just stand there laughing until our stomachs hurt. We did everything in the computer lab except the practicals. Plus, we randomly talked to juniors of Class 3 or 4 grade and made them our friends. And of course, we ate *golgappas* in class while experimenting with different stuff with them, trying to invent new combinations that somehow never worked but always made us laugh harder. Also, I still remember how we once stole a friend's bottle and gifted it to her on her birthday! It was truly hilarious to see her reaction. My friends and their acts are some of the best memories, as even if we are just young, dumb, and broke, we still have love to give.

It is ironic how time passes so gently yet still so fast: from the first day at school I'll reach the last.

A bond that stays

Now, I'm in 12th grade and school is going to end soon. Still, there is a flow of memories in my mind, and somewhere I'm going to miss the school too, which I found annoying at a certain point. It is ironic how time passes so gently yet still so fast: from the first day at school I'll reach the last. This beautiful journey will end and a new journey will begin. It's all the magic of time, but the pristine part is that my friendship stayed where it was and grew stronger than ever - like a thread which is tied around our hands and refuses to break even when the weather is harsh. Through every argument, every silly fight, every exam stress, every hangout, and every celebration, that thread only became stronger.

The bad days will come and go; the good days will blossom on their own. It's our friendship that ignites the most, so that the dark days will end on their own. May these bonds never break, as we intend to tease each other even when we are very old.

At last, thank me that I'm your friend, as you guys will never get someone as best as me.

Your beloved,
Faria

(The author of this letter is Farira, a student of Class 12 from Delhi)

PHOTOS: GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO



A letter to my younger self



PHOTO: GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

Dear younger me,

Hi! I don't really know how to begin this letter. "Dear little me" sounds too sweet, while "Dear troublemaker" sounds a little too accurate! So, let's keep it simple: Dear Me.

There are so many things I want to tell that younger version of myself: mistakes that became lessons, changes that made a difference, funny school memories, and the people who made those years special.

Back then, school probably seemed to be mostly about books, marks, homework and examinations. But with time, it becomes clear that some of the most important lessons never appear in a textbook.

Let's begin with one mistake that taught a lesson that stayed for a long time.

It was the beginning of a new academic year. The syllabus was not very large, so there seemed to be plenty of time. Most subjects received proper attention, but somehow, one subject was left until the morning of an online examination. Yes, the plan was to become an expert in an entire subject in just one morning!

Apparently, confidence had studied harder than preparation!

The aim was to get the first rank. The other subjects were going well, so everything seemed promising.

Then came the result. Most of the marks were good, except for that one subject. Unfortunately, that single subject managed to pull the rank all the way down to seventh.

Seventh!

That result was disappointing, but it also taught something that a hundred pieces of advice might not have taught.

"One careless day can teach you what a hundred careful days cannot."

Success is not built by studying only when an examination is standing at the door and knocking loudly. It comes from small efforts made regularly. The habit of saying, "There is still plenty of time," slowly changed into, "If there is time, why not use it wisely?"

Being organised became more important. Paying attention in class became a habit instead of thinking everything could be studied later. And "later" turned out to be a dangerous word for a student. Sometimes it quietly becomes "the night before the exam."

One important lesson also became clear: making a mistake does not make someone a failure. Refusing to learn from it is what keeps the mistake alive. That examination did not decide the future. Instead, it showed how much could change with a little more responsibility. But school life was never only about marks. Some of the best memories came from moments when fun completely defeated seriousness!

One memory that still makes me smile is sharing food with friends. Someone would quietly open a packet of biscuits, and within seconds, the whole group would know about it. One person would say, "Just one," while reaching for three! Whenever a teacher walked past, everyone would suddenly sit straight, open a book and look extremely interested in studying. Those little moments became some of the memories worth remembering.

Another favourite memory is playing Dumb Charades with friends. One team would act out a Tamil movie without saying a single word, while the other team tried to guess the title. Sometimes the acting was so funny that everyone started laughing before even guessing the movie! Every correct guess felt like a huge victory, and every failed attempt became another reason to laugh. It was only a game, but the teamwork and laughter made it unforgettable. Then came special occasions like Annual Day, when the whole school seemed to come alive. The decorations, performances, excitement and nervousness made the day completely different from an ordinary school day. Everyone simply wanted to enjoy the moment. Looking back, those days feel precious because nobody realised that one day these ordinary school memories would become the ones we missed the most.

And among all these memories, there is one person who made school life even more meaningful: my favourite teacher. She constantly encourages students to achieve more. It is not only about getting good marks. She wants students to become successful, confident and responsible people. She is also amazingly good at teaching, guiding, organising and encouraging. Sometimes I wonder whether her timetable secretly has more than 24 hours!

She has a special talent for giving ideas too. Just when everyone thinks everything has already been understood, another idea appears and makes the class think, "Why didn't we think of that?"

If people who sleep late are called night owls, perhaps she should be called an idea owl, because ideas seem to follow her everywhere!

Behind all the humour, though, there is something genuinely special. She believes students can achieve more than they sometimes believe about themselves. A teacher's encouraging words may sound small in the moment, but they can stay in a student's mind for years.

Dear Me, there will be more mistakes, achievements, disappointing days and proud moments. There will be laughter with friends, nervousness before examinations and lessons hidden inside unexpected failures.

Years from now, every chapter studied and every mark scored may not remain in memory. But the people who encouraged us, the mistakes that changed us, the laughter shared with friends, the food passed around secretly, the silly games and the excitement of Annual Day will remain much longer.

So, Dear Me, don't be afraid of making mistakes. Learn from them. Appreciate the people who guide you. Celebrate progress, even when it seems small. Most importantly, keep becoming a better version of yourself.

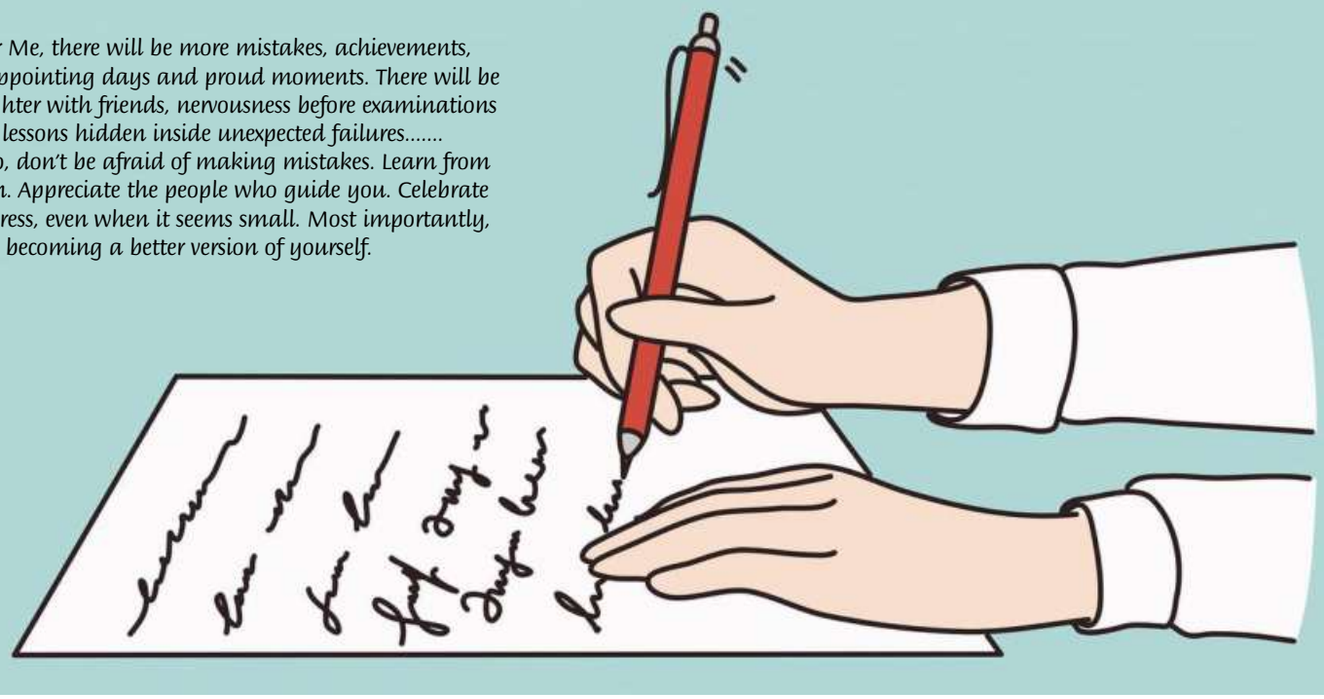
School is not only preparing students for examinations. Through friendships, failures, teachers, laughter and everyday experiences, it is preparing us for life.

And whenever the thought comes, "There is plenty of time," remember that seventh-rank version of yourself.

Trust me.
Yours,
Hanithra

(The author of this letter is M Hanithra, a student of class 8 from Panruti, Tamil Nadu)

Dear Me, there will be more mistakes, achievements, disappointing days and proud moments. There will be laughter with friends, nervousness before examinations and lessons hidden inside unexpected failures.....
So, don't be afraid of making mistakes. Learn from them. Appreciate the people who guide you. Celebrate progress, even when it seems small. Most importantly, keep becoming a better version of yourself.



STUDENT LETTERS

The years that made me

A chart his father painted still hangs in a first-grade classroom. As he prepares to leave, this Class 12 student looks back on the years that shaped him.



Dear school,

Twelve years may sound like just a number, but for me, it holds a lifetime of memories. From entering this school as a young boy with uncertain thoughts to now being ready to face the world with confidence, you've shaped me into a good individual. You've been my second home, giving me a place where I truly felt at home. The teachers here have not just taught me lessons; they have also instilled values and ethics that are truly necessary for a responsible citizen. I was offered countless opportunities, and participating in them not only earned me medals and certificates but also left me with valuable lessons.

When I first entered this school to write the entrance examination, I had many questions and curious thoughts. I still remember the slide area where I first sat for the examination. And today, as I am studying in Class 12, every nook and cranny of this school is familiar to me. When I was in Class 1, my father painted a chart for Project Day, which was filled with animals in a zoo, and even today, it can be seen hanging in the Class 1 classroom. Every time I go to the Kaveri Block, I still look for the chart, and seeing it gives me a sense of nostalgia. (Our school has different blocks named after the life-giving rivers of our nation). Even when I was in Class 8, my father was asked to make three cut-outs for the Cultural Programme, and these too have been preserved in the school, as I was recently told by my Class 3 teacher.

Moving to the next stage

During the transition from the primary to the secondary stage, the next two years of schooling were conducted online due to COVID-19. What I remember most amusingly was that we were given online yoga classes. We would see our friends on the screen doing yoga and meditation, while some of us would switch our cameras off, even as the teacher repeatedly asked us to turn them on. I still remember the date — 1 November 2021 — when we entered the school after the lockdown.

From Class 8 onwards, I participated in many inter-school competitions because of my interest in art, and in almost all the competitions I participated in, I won prizes. In Class 8, I was given the role of Sri Shankaracharya during the school Cultural Programme, which remains one of the best memories of my school life. Every time the school Cultural Programme was planned, I wanted to be a part of the compering team. However, I was given roles in dramas, dance performances and other programmes.

Then came one of the most important parts of my schooling: Class 10. During the early days, I had some self-doubt, but as the days passed, I gained clarity and confidence to face the board examinations. As the exam days drew closer, every early-morning wake-up seemed to promise me the best results. Unfortunately, my mother was hospitalised during my board examinations, and I was sent to my aunt's house. Despite the emotional turmoil, I assured myself that the best way to tackle the situation was to concentrate on my board examinations and make my parents proud. Those days remain deeply unforgettable moments of my life. Although many of my classmates left the school after Class 10, I continued in the same school.

In Class 11, I was given the opportunity to serve the school as the School Vice-Captain. To be honest, initially, I faced many uncertainties and struggles. But as the days passed, the role helped me become bolder and more confident. During that year, I was also part of the compering team for the Culturals, and those days still evoke a sense of nostalgia. The following year, I was entrusted with an even greater responsibility as the School Captain. Standing before the entire school during morning assemblies and being involved in various school events gradually became a part of my everyday life. Every morning assembly, every school event — each taught me the art of public speaking, the value of teamwork, and the maturity to handle responsibilities. Being enrolled in IIT-JEE classes made me a little busy. Looking back, I realise that these experiences shaped me in ways that a classroom lesson alone never could.



PHOTOS: MAGNIFIC

Looking back with gratitude

Yet, when I think of my school life, it is not only the positions I held or the prizes I received that come to mind, but the people and moments behind them. I have been fortunate to have teachers who saw potential in me even before I recognised it myself.

What I will miss most are the ordinary moments — conversations between classes, laughter with friends, excitement before an event, nervousness before an examination and the little celebrations after getting something right.

I am also grateful to our Correspondent, Principal, Vice Principal and Assistant Vice Principal, whose guidance, encouragement and vision have helped create an environment where I could learn, participate, take responsibility and gradually grow into the person I am today.

As I prepare to leave, I realise that I have grown alongside this school. Soon, I will walk through these familiar gates into a new chapter, carrying its lessons, friendships and memories with me. Years from now, I may forget many textbook lessons, but I will never forget how this school made me feel.

Dear School, I may be leaving your gates, but a part of me will always remain here. I did not merely study here; I grew here. As I step into the world, I hope to carry your values with me, pursue my dream of joining the Civil Services, and one day serve this land in a way that makes this school proud to call me its student.

Umesh S
Class XII
Sholinghur, Tamil Nadu

Pave-it-Yourself (PIY)

Sometimes you don't seize opportunities; you make them for yourself. This is exactly what Ritkriti Dayal tells her juniors to do.

Dear juniors,

If you had met me before middle school, you probably wouldn't recognise the person writing this.

I was quiet. Very quiet, actually. I would not even talk much to teachers; I had to prepare a whole script mentally in order to talk face to face. I had opportunities in my path, but I never really paid attention to them.

Somewhere in my head, I made an assumption: If I was meant to do something, perhaps someone would notice me and give me the opportunity, right in my hands.

Sometimes, it did. I was selected for competitions by my teachers, and I did fairly well as well, but somewhere or the other, I knew I could do a lot more — I just had to find the path.

I still remember being disappointed when I wasn't selected for the Junior School Council in Class 5. I was only ten, but it felt enormous to me. I remember wondering what those students had that I didn't. Looking back, I realise that perhaps the disappointment wasn't really about the badge. It was about wanting to be a part of something and not knowing how to get there.

In middle school, I often saw seniors working for several events, organisations and projects and eventually even I started to long for the same along with which I started to learn something that seemed painfully obvious to everyone except me:the path that I was not able to find didn't really exist, I had to pave it myself.

I did not wake up the next morning as a fearless, outspoken person who suddenly enjoyed talking to strangers, or who could suddenly speak on stage with no fumbles. In fact letting go of hesitation took me years.

It began with small things, reaching out to teachers to volunteer for events, filling forms for several activities before the thought of "am I good enough" struck.

I got rejections and failures more than the success, but more than all of that, I gained experience

For a long time, I thought confidence had to come first. I thought I had to become confident enough to speak, participate, apply and take responsibility. I eventually learnt that I had got it backwards. I wasn't confident while taking up the opportunities. Taking up the opportunities was what made me confident.

I tried everything — speaking, writing, drama, science projects, debates, graphic design, and whatnot.

Over the years, one small step led to another. I began participating more, speaking more, volunteering more and that is how my teachers found my potential — way before I could myself.

Breakthrough phase

I started writing because a teacher suggested that I try it, and I haven't really stopped since. Somewhere along the way, words that had once only existed in my notebooks took me to competitions, publications, awards and eventually even to becoming an author and co-author. But if you asked the younger me whether she thought any of that would happen, she probably would have laughed.

I eventually reached beyond the familiar walls of school and introduced myself to people I did not know (although talking to them over calls was still a daunting task), I applied for opportunities without knowing whether I will be selected or not and put myself before people who might reject it. Not every message received a reply. Not every application worked out. Not every attempt was successful. And strangely, that became less frightening with time. Not because rejection stopped hurting, but because it stopped feeling like a verdict.

But something had changed: I had stopped measuring opportunities only by whether they chose me. I had started choosing them too.

The strangest part is that I did not notice myself changing. I didn't wake up one morning and realise, Oh, I am confident now.

In fact, I think I only noticed when I looked at the difference between my Class 11 and Class 12 self. The girl who once needed a mental script to speak to a teacher was now approaching teachers with ideas, volunteering for responsibilities, speaking to people she had never met and putting herself forward for things without first deciding that she probably wasn't good enough.

Reflection

I still overthink. I still get nervous. I still fumble sometimes.

Now that I am in my last year of school, looking back at the journey feels almost surreal. I have spent nearly fifteen years here — I came in as a toddler, and I am now preparing to leave as a young adult. Somewhere between those two versions of me, I have grown, stumbled, changed, discovered new interests and slowly understood who I want to become. And I know that I did not do that alone. My teachers and my school have seen potential in me at moments when I could not see it myself. Different teachers have opened different doors for me — one saw a researcher in me and helped me find my way into a research internship, another saw a writer before I had the confidence to call myself one, a senior once believed I had enough potential to serve as a core member in my club even though I was joining it for the first time ever, and a mentor once believed I deserved a place in the School Council enough to put my name forward at the very last moment. Some of those opportunities worked out; some did not. But what stayed constant was the willingness of people here to give me another chance, another responsibility, another reason to try. Even my failures never became a reason for the school to stop believing in me. The appreciation, the laurels, the badges and the positions will always be special, but what means far more to me is knowing that, throughout these fifteen years, there were people who kept seeing possibilities in me until I learnt to see them in myself. This school did not just witness me growing up; it was a part of the process. I came here learning to find my place in a classroom, and I will leave having learnt to find my place in the world.

Five years after that Class 5 disappointment, I finally wore the School Council badge I had once wanted so badly. And surprisingly, when I looked at it, I didn't think about the badge. I thought about the ten-year-old me who had believed that opportunities had to be handed to her. She was not foolish. She was simply waiting for someone to show her the path.

Sometimes there is no path. You have to make one. So, to the juniors reading this, I don't want you to remember me as the senior who had it all figured out. I didn't.

If there is one thing I want you to take from my years here, it is not to become fearless. Become willing. Willing to raise your hand. Willing to ask. Willing to hear a no. Willing to try something you might not be immediately good at. Willing to let people see you learning. Because you don't have to know where an opportunity will take you before you take the first step towards it. I certainly didn't. And yet, somehow, those little steps brought me here — to my final year, writing this letter to you.

So don't wait for your path to appear. Start walking.

Ritkriti Dayal
Grade XII
Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh

PHOTO: MAGNIFIC



Students' DAY SPECIAL



STUDENT LETTERS

I changed my dreams, not my curiosity

One may think changing dreams is confusion; but that's not really the case

Dear reader,

Maybe you are reading this while wondering what you want to become. Perhaps you already have a clear answer. Perhaps, like me, your answer keeps changing.

When I was younger, my dreams changed almost as often as the books I read. After watching '12th Fail', I wanted to become an IAS officer. After '3 Idiots', I imagined becoming an engineer. At different times, I even wanted to become an astronaut or a detective.

Changing dreams confusion

For a long time, I thought this meant I was confused. Now, as a Class 11 student, I see it differently. Perhaps I was not confused. Perhaps I was simply curious. Every new story opened another possibility. Changing your dreams does not necessarily mean that you are lost. Sometimes, it means that you are exploring.

A major change came when I watched H.C. Verma sir speaking about curious minds and teaching. Later, I saw David Attenborough in The Hindu Sunday Magazine. I was fascinated by the way he had spent his life observing and explaining the natural world. Today, I want to become a naturalist and environmentalist. I want to understand nature closely and help people realise that protecting the environment belongs to all of us.

But perhaps the biggest change in my life began with something simpler: books.

At the beginning of Class 10, my English teacher, Anil sir, encouraged us to read fiction and non-fiction. Then Ritu Goyal ma'am introduced me to her father, Ramesh sir. His library had roughly 3,000–4,000 books. He suggested books to me, and slowly reading became more than a school activity.

But my education has never come only from books.

Thanks to my teachers

My first teacher was my mother, Asha ma'am, who supported and encouraged me from the beginning. Shrasth Goyal sir helped remove my fear of mathematics and increased my interest in it. Yogesh sir has given me academic strength and motivation and has also become a close friend. Rakesh sir made me think more carefully about what I listen to.

Sushil sir, my Information Technology teacher, introduced me to Osho. Our conversations about morality and honesty often continued beyond the classroom and made me think about the person I want to become. Rama Shastri ma'am encouraged me to think about truth and philosophy.

Mamta ma'am, my Social Studies teacher, awakened my interest in current affairs, politics and the way society and the world around us work. She made me more aware of what was happening beyond the walls of my classroom. Jaipal sir, my Hindi teacher, is perhaps one of the most energetic teachers I have ever met. He shared many thoughtful and practical lessons with us, and several of those ideas still help me in real life.



PHOTO: MAGNIFIC

Ritu Goyal ma'am increased my interest in biology, taught me scientific thinking and introduced me to Professor Ramesh sir.

To all these teachers, and especially to my mother, I want to say thank you. Learning from each of you have shaped a different part of me.

Building character

I also think education should make us more sensitive to people who need help. On birthdays and special occasions, it is natural to buy expensive things, decorate our surroundings or put up large flexes and posters. But perhaps we can sometimes celebrate differently. Instead of spending everything on things that will soon be forgotten, we could use a part of it to help poor and elderly people who struggle with basic needs. A celebration becomes more meaningful when our happiness gives someone else hope.

This connects with a line that means a lot to me: "When there is life, there is hope."

Even a person sitting on the roadside and asking for help may carry a hope that we cannot immediately see — the hope that someone will offer a meal, that tonight's food may be a little better, or that tomorrow may bring some kindness or a new opportunity.

Life can become extremely difficult, but as long as we are here, the possibility of change remains. Sometimes, a small act of kindness can become the reason someone believes that tomorrow may be better.

This way of thinking also made me look differently at my family. We should respect our parents and grandparents, even when we do not understand or agree with everything they say. Respect, however, does not mean accepting every tradition without understanding it.

For example, my grandmother sometimes tells me that after eating something sweet, I should taste a little salt before leaving home. I could simply do it and move on. But my curiosity makes me ask: Why? What is its significance?

We can listen to their explanation, understand where a tradition came from and then think for ourselves. We can question something without disrespecting the person who taught it to us.

Uncertain future

I know many students worry about their future. If you do not know what you want to become, you are not behind.

Instead of asking only, "What do I want to become?", perhaps ask, "What do I want to understand?"

Most importantly, ask: What are you doing? Why are you doing it? How does it work? But also learn to listen. Talk to teachers, parents and grandparents. Read books by people who think differently from you.

I still do not know exactly what my future will look like. I want to make the most of my education, find work that genuinely interests me and become independent. Perhaps my plans will change again, and I am okay with that.

We are not finished people. We are still becoming.

Yours sincerely,
Viraj singh, Class 11,
Nanwana, Haryana

Blink and you'll miss it

School life is funny, you wait for the holidays, and the next thing you know, you want to go back.



PHOTO: MAGNIFIC

Dear reader,

Why is it that we spend all year waiting for the holidays, only to spend our entire holiday wishing we were back in the school hallways with our friends?

We've all had those bittersweet moments when the long school years finally come to an end. Though school is something that I never truly adored, the final chapters and days of it have become stories that will forever stay close to my heart. The long school days seem to pass in a quick blur.

It's funny how the school year always feels like an eternity when it starts, stretching out in an expanse of timetables and countdowns. Which is kind of ironic, because ever since the very first week of school starts, we find ourselves constantly thinking about when the exams will finally be over, when the holidays will start, or when the school year will draw to a close. The truth is, we are always looking forward to the fun events planned throughout our year at school. Yet, as time quietly passes and we realise there are only a handful of days left before summer vacation, we look back and wonder why we took all those ordinary moments for granted.

The legendary bucket list

When I finally entered eighth grade, my friends and I decided we needed to do something completely different during the final weeks of school we had left. Between all the piling projects, nerve-wracking exams, school events, and our endlessly hectic schedules, we were more than ecstatic when our final exams were finally over. All that remained of our school year was one month of pure leisure and free periods the entire day. And it was precisely during those golden hours that we first drafted our legendary '8th grade bucket list' on the back of my chemistry notebook. It wasn't anything official; it was just a series of bullet points carefully and hurriedly jotted down on a blank, splotchy page on the back of my old notebook about all the things we wanted to accomplish before 8th grade closed its doors. Our list had over twenty ambitious goals to achieve in just two weeks, ranging from random things like organising an event and planning a spontaneous hangout, all the way to pulling a harmless prank on our unsuspecting classmates.

Needless to say, those last two weeks were some of the most vibrant, fun-filled times of our entire lives. Although we barely managed to complete five items on that wild list, we still created an ocean of amazing memories that I know will stay with us forever. Reflecting on it all made me realise how much of our school life we take for granted. We take our teachers for granted, our friends for granted, and the daily rhythm of our routines for granted. And then there are those tiny instances which seem insignificant, but in fact matter a great deal, like that time when we first walked into a brand-new school, the nervous thrill of giving a presentation in front of the whole class, or the simple joy of playing a chaotic class game with all our classmates and so much more.

The smaller details

Think about the sound of rain tapping against the classroom window, or the shared glance when someone cracks a quiet joke across the room. Think about the comforting weight of a heavy school bag and the familiar footsteps rushing down the hallway as the final bell rings. These are the details that build our stories.

Yet, my absolute favourite moments of all are the ones where there are no classes scheduled for the entire day, and we have all the time in the world to spend time with our friends, talk about life, and pursue our hobbies.

So, I would like to ask you, "what are you waiting for?" Why not take out a piece of paper right now and write your own bucket list? Don't wait for the final weeks of the year to start collecting memories. Stop taking the ordinary days for granted. Plan that spontaneous hangout, laugh a little louder in the hallways, cherish your friends, and make every single second count before the bell rings.

The truly incredible thing about being a student is how remarkably versatile we can be. Despite our crazy schedules, while delicately balancing tough academics alongside all our extracurricular commitments, we still find these tiny, radiant instances of joy and share them with the people we love.

It's moments like these that make me wish time would just stand still.

Yours truly
Gargi Kiran, Class 9,
Bengaluru, Karnataka

